Driving

By Ray Romano

SPEAKER: **(Pg 165-181)** I'd rather drive than fly, because when I fly, I'm afraid the person I'm sitting next to is going to want to talk. I'm a friendly guy. It's not that I'm unsociable. I'm just not a great conversationalist. And long flights can get very tough on a non-talker like myself. What's made things easier is learning some of the things you can do, tactfully of course, to let the person next to you know you're not the talking type.

First of all, you can't let **any** conversation begin. Because once it's started, there's no proper point to say, "You've been very nice, but I'd like for both of us to stop talking."

Unfortunately, people interpret many things as an invitation to begin a conversation. It could be anything from eye-contact to saying "God bless you" after they sneeze. So, what you have to do is cut off all possible avenues of communication. Your best bet is just to walk on the plane wearing headphones, a surgical mask, and looking through a View-Master. I know that'll work, because at home, it's the way I go to bed.

People think I drive because I'm afraid to fly. That's not it at all. Not only do I know that you are statistically more likely to get into an accident in an automobile, but the way my mind works, I worry that while I'm driving, a plane might crash *into my car.* I'm going to be neurotic whether I'm ***driving*** or ***flying***.

INTRODUCTION

*And to be honest, people on the road today have every right to be a little neurotic. Gen Z has taken their place behind the wheel and survey says . . . (in the tradition of Family Feud): *38% of Gen Zers look at their phone more frequently when behind the wheel; 34% video chat while driving and 24% use social media; followed closely by the Millennials at 23%.*

It's time to ditch the digital and go old school with some driving tips, tricks and observations from Everything and a Kite . . . It's Driving by Ray Romano

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New York City (Replace with name of your town or state) drivers have always had a bad reputation. And I'm not going to say it isn't true, but I will tell you what the problem is. It's the testing. It's just way too easy to get a license. I don't know what the written exam in your part of the country consists of, but it can't be any easier than ours. Here you go, Sample question: A blind person is crossing the road. What is your course of action?

A: Stop. Let him go by.

B: Nudge him a little, so he knows you're there.

C: Speed up. Aim for the dog.

Actually, I've thought of a very simple solution to the New York City driving problem. They should require all drivers to put one of those "How's My Driving?" stickers with the 800 numbers on their car. I'm sure you've seen these on the back of trucks. My favorite one is "How's My Driving? If you have any complaints, or compliments, call this number. . ." OK, look: complaints I can understand. But ***compliments****?* Folks, whose life is that boring? Who's making that phone call?

"Hello, Sternberger Moving Company? I was out on the road and happened to catch truck number forty-two? He backed into this loading dock. . . it was *artwork.* Then, on the way out, he made a U-turn. . . and I wept. Is he ever going to be in town again, because the kids would love him."

Of course, you couldn't have 800 numbers for ***every*** car, because the call volume would overload the phone system.

"Hello? I'm leaving you a message because you just cut me off in traffic. Yeah, you're staring at me right now. Looks like you thought it was my fault. Hold on, I'm going to give you *a rude gesture*. There you go. Ha ha. OK, now we're at a red light. You're getting out of your car and approaching mine. Tell you what: let me call you back."

Something happened to me one time on the road that still gives me nightmares. I was driving to a gig, and I noticed a spider on the windshield of my car.

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OK, I know that doesn't sound like much drama to you, but they give me the heebie-jeebies! So, there was this big hairy spider right in the middle of my windshield, and all I knew was I wanted him off, pronto. The plan I developed was simple: turn on the wipers and knock him into orbit. For a moment, however, I was torn. What if all the wipers do is push him a little closer to the driver's side window? Then what? I think he's gone, I get out of the car, he leaps down my throat and hatches his eggs in my stomach. I didn't know what to do. If I had been near a car wash, that might have solved everything, but I was on the highway, which also ruled out pulling into a garage and getting a new windshield.

I kept one eye on the spider, and one eye on the road. I couldn't keep that up much longer without getting into an accident. So, after a few minutes of trying to "pray" him away, I had to take a chance. I activated the wipers. Swish, swish, swish, swish. . . Nothing. The spider didn't budge. My cheapo wipers must have been warped, because they were gliding right over the eight-legged beast without moving him a millimeter. Desperately, I turned on the washer to try and flood him out.

Still nothing. Whatever fear I was feeling at the moment was magnified tenfold. I was in my own little horror movie, and I had just gotten a phone call: ***"We've traced the spider, *sir/ma'am* -- He's ON THE INSIIIIIIIDE!"***

I'm too embarrassed to tell the end of this story. But here's a hint: Moonroof.

Aside from spiders, the only other thing I fear while driving is the dreaded "sleep dip." Oh man. . . you ever do one of those? Usually they happen late at night, although it's not a rule. But there you are: behind the wheel of your car, and you're starting to get tired. Your eyelids get a little heavy, and without realizing it, you start to close them just a tiny bit.

Then your head gets a little heavy. Suddenly your chin drops to your chest. The jolt snaps you back awake and your head pops up. ***"Wha . . . ? WHOA! Was I just sleeping?!"***

You can't believe it. ***"Oh my God, I was sleeping!"*** The first thing you do is look around to see if you killed anybody. ***"I think that guy was lying there already. . ."***

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The sleep dip is not only frightening, it's frustrating. How many times are you at home, in your bed, in your pajamas, it's cozy, it's warm, and you can't sleep at all? Now you're going sixty miles an hour, and you're catching ZZZs behind the wheel.

You can't stop it. And it's not from a lack of effort. You try all the tricks to keep yourself awake. You turn on the radio, you open a window, you slap your face. I'll tell you what I do to stay awake -- let me pass on a real tip just to break up the boredom of a long car ride.

Over the years, I've developed a little game that I can play endlessly. The rules are very simple. As a matter of fact, there's only one: Come up with a sentence that has never been said before in the entire history of language. That's it. That's the whole game. The whole key is this: pretend your life ***depends*** on coming up with a string of words -- not just nonsense, but a real sentence -- that hasn't been uttered by anyone, anytime, anywhere. Let me give you an example. ***"Give me back my fudge suitcase!"***

Now, I don't know if that sentence has been said before. But we're off to a good start, because I think we can all agree it probably hasn't been said very ***often.*** But still, one could probably imagine some kind of situation where "Give me back my fudge suitcase" might have been said in the past. Which brings us to the next phase of the game: once you come up with your "Never Been Said" sentence, you have to try and figure out a scenario where it ***could*** have been said. This part is actually the most fun.

"Give me back my fudge suitcase!" Hmm. OK, how about this? Some guy's coming back from Hershey Park, Pennsylvania, and he's loaded up his bags with fudge. He's in the airport, some gung-ho security guy confiscates his luggage. . . I think you can figure out the rest. [Wait!] "Give me back my fudge suitcase" could have been a line from the movie *Willy Wonka and the Chocolate Factory.*

See what I'm saying? It's not that easy to come up with a "Never Been Said" phrase. "Give me back my fudge suitcase" is actually kind of weak. But here's a tip. Sometimes you can just alter the sentence a little, and that will make all the difference. Check it out: ***"Give me back my fudge suitcase, Rockhead."*** I think, statistically, we've improved our odds. I mean,

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how many airport security guards are there named Rockhead?

To be honest, the most challenging part of the game is to keep the sentence short and realistic. Anyone can just keep adding words to the end, but stuff like, ***"Officer Tongue Depressor, could you check under my rumble seat to see if any of the goose-loving woodchucks have cut through my brake line, and also I'm itchy"*** -- to be honest, it's kind of contrived.

Here's a list of some of the phrases I've been working on over the years. Please don't be intimidated. You have to understand that while you're just starting out, this is my life's work.

- "If hernias were rainbows, I'd be Raymond Burr."
- "Shredded Wheat would make a silly pistol."
- "Moonlight is the plumber's pudding."
- "I'm one headlock short of making colonel."

Not bad, right? Listen, you might be laughing at me right now, but next time you're driving with nothing to do, you're going to be playing that game faster than a leg warmer can yell at a helmet! There's another one for you. That's without even trying.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
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**** Introduction source for statistics***
https://news.nationwide.com/its-getting-scarier-on-americas-roadways/

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